

To the Bahá'ís of the World

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Dearly loved Friends,

28.1 When He arrived in the Holy Land, exactly one hundred years ago today, at the conclusion of His “epoch-making journeys” to Egypt and the West, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá eschewed any ceremony or fanfare just as He had at His departure. But between

His going and His return, a defining period in Bahá'í history

had unfolded—a “glorious chapter,” in the words of Shoghi Effendi, during which “seeds of undreamt-of potentialities”

had been sown, “with the hand of the Center of the Covenant

Himself,” in the “fertile fields” to the west.

28.2 The accounts of ‘Abdu’l-Bahá’s travels and of the effect He

had on those who met Him are legion. Some went to extraordinary

lengths to enter His presence—going by boat, by foot, or

even under railway trains—and, by the urgency of their desire

to see Him, imprinted themselves on the consciousness of future

generations of adults and children. The testimonies of those who were transformed by even a brief, sometimes near wordless

encounter with their beloved Master remain deeply stirring. In

the wide array of visitors He received—rich and poor, black and white, indigenous and émigré—the universal embrace of

His Father’s Faith was unmistakably in evidence. It is impos-

sible to adequately gauge the full scope of what ‘Abdu’l-Bahá

accomplished within this period. Many of the seeds He planted,
and which He nurtured towards maturity through an extensive correspondence that He maintained until the end of His life,
would blossom into a steadfast community capable of bearing
the great weight of work in the years to come, supporting the first structures of national Bahá'í administration and beginning
to act on the Master's longing that the divine teachings be
brought to every city and shore.

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION^{28.3} The friends have, of course, called these points to mind during this centenary period, and they have done much more besides. As we hoped, they have given their attention to the tasks before them, drawing inspiration from the Master's potent example and timeless counsels. We have been pleased to see how, in particular, efforts to bring spiritual education to children and young people have flourished. Work to establish the institution of the Mashriqu'l-Adhkár, the singular significance of which 'Abdu'l-Bahá stressed so pointedly during His visit to the United States, is making progress in eight countries, whilst in every land, devotional meetings—a communal aspect of the godly life—are thriving. The Bahá'í community's increasing engagement with the life of society, which is enabling it to offer a fresh perspective to formal and informal conversations of all kinds, carries distinct echoes of 'Abdu'l-Bahá's deep concern for the needs of the age. In clusters where the demands created by the scale and intensity of activity are most acutely felt, more complex schemes of coordination are emerging through a gradual and patient process of learning. In certain regions of the world where the institutions are overseeing special initiatives, an influx of eager pioneers is helping to strengthen the foundations of sustained growth and broaden the scope of what can be achieved by a community. The work of expansion and consolidation is advancing through the unflagging labors of countless devoted souls who have, in numerous ways, followed 'Abdu'l-Bahá in treading the plane of sacrifice. The heightened

capacity of a worldwide community to assist populations

to move towards the vision conceived by Bahá'u'lláh was conspicuously evident at the Eleventh International Bahá'í

Convention. That same capacity was vividly illustrated in

the film *Frontiers of Learning* and explored in detail in the

document *Insights from the Frontiers of Learning*, which have

stimulated profound reflection not only on the dynamics of

growth but also on the means to treat the roots of many a social

malady. And in the closing months of this three-year period

came the most spectacular demonstration of how the present generation has responded to the call of service to humankind

singularly embodied in the Person of the Master: the gathering

of more than eighty thousand youth in a four-month series of

conferences held in well over a hundred far-strewn locations

across the globe.

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ferences shared essential attributes in common—the meticulous

care that characterized the preparations, the oneness of mind

that was palpable at each gathering, the energy that has surged

therefrom. In the strenuous efforts they made to attend can

be glimpsed the depth of commitment felt by the participants. Some labored with great sacrifice to raise the necessary funds from meagre resources; in other cases, by explaining the

noble purpose and wholesome nature of the events, the friends

obtained special permission from the authorities for the ar -

rangements. Shipping lines were persuaded to change course to collect participants, while some youth walked for days to reach a venue. Reports of the insights generated, the creativity re-

leased, the moving testimonies delivered on each occasion and,

most of all, the impetus lent to acts of service are evidence that those present were touched by spiritual forces more enduring,

more deeply rooted than anything that could be elicited by the

thrill of fellowship and large numbers alone. It is most heart-

ening that tens of thousands of youth, unwilling to succumb

to triviality or to settle for easy conformity, have now been brought within the widening embrace of a conversation and

pattern of action of far-reaching consequence regarding how to

live a coherent life and be an agent of spiritual and social transformation. The new levels of collaboration these conferences

demand of the institutions to mobilize and guide such large

numbers and prepare the host of facilitators to assist them; the

wholehearted collective effort required of the community as it

threw wide open the circle of participation and witnessed the profound effect of doing so; the serious commitment evinced

by the individual who, drawing on the concepts explored in the

conference materials, is joining the tens of thousands occupied

with reaching out to hundreds of thousands of others—these,

together, have contributed to a marked rise in capacity in the three protagonists upon whom the success of the Five Year Plan

depends. And while we acknowledge that the youth are at the

forefront of this advance, its distinguishing feature is that the community rose as one to support, encourage, and champion

this phenomenon, and now rejoices to see itself progress as an

interdependent, organic whole, readier to meet the imperatives

of this day.

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION28.5 Given all this, we have no hesitation in recognizing that

what these developments reveal is an advance in the process of

entry by troops of a kind not experienced heretofore.

28.6 We call upon all to reflect upon the significance of the

endeavor in which the community of the Greatest Name is engaged, the purpose of which the Master strove to underline so

often in the course of His travels, and to rededicate themselves

to contribute their share to its outcome. “Try with all your

hearts,” He urged one audience, “to be willing channels for God’s Bounty. For I say unto you that He has chosen you to be

His messengers of love throughout the world, to be His bearers

of spiritual gifts to man, to be the means of spreading unity and concord on the earth.” “Perchance,” He remarked on another

occasion, “God willing, this terrestrial world may become as

a celestial mirror upon which we may behold the imprint of

the traces of Divinity, and the fundamental qualities of a new

creation may be reflected from the reality of love shining in human hearts.” To this end do all your efforts tend. During the

second half of the Five Year Plan, the society-building power of

the Faith must be released within thousands of clusters where programs of growth need to be initiated, reinforced, or ex-

tended. The challenge for Bahá'í institutions and their agencies

will be to furnish the means to accompany all those who cherish

a pure and earnest desire for a better world, whatever their

degree of involvement in the process of spiritual education so far, and help them translate that desire into the practical steps

that day by day and week by week accrete to build vibrant,

flourishing communities. How fitting that, at this hour, a gener -

ation of youth has come into its own, ready to assume growing responsibility, since its contribution to the work at hand will prove decisive in the months and years ahead. In our prayers at

the Sacred Threshold, we will entreat the Almighty to sustain

all those who would be a part of this immense undertaking, who prefer the true prosperity of others over their own ease

and leisure, and whose eyes are fixed upon ‘Abdu’l-Bahá for

a flawless pattern of how to be; all this, that “those who walk

in darkness should come into the light” and “those who are

excluded should join the inner circle of the Kingdom.”

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]